ERA 12

Labor & Immigration

1865 – 1900

Workers · the labor movement · immigration & the city

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Who paid the human price for the Gilded Age—and how did they respond?

KEY TERMS

Child labor · the Knights of Labor & AFL · Haymarket · Ellis Island · tenements · the Chinese Exclusion Act

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 6.7–6.9 · AMSCO Ch. 6.7–6.9

WHO BUILT THE INDUSTRIAL GIANT?

The Workers of the Gilded Age

Working Conditions

I

Long Hours

Laborers worked **12-hour days, 6 days a week**—often for pennies an hour.

II

Dangerous Work

Unsafe machines and no safety laws meant frequent injuries and death.

III

No Security

Workers could be fired at will, easily replaced, and had no benefits.

Child Labor

- By 1900 nearly **2 million children** worked in mills, mines, and factories.
- Children were cheap, small enough to reach into machines—and voiceless.
- **Child labor** became a rallying cry for reform.



SECTION

The Labor Movement

An Age of Strikes

1877

Great Railroad Strike

The first nationwide strike—crushed by federal troops.

1886

Haymarket Affair

A Chicago bomb kills police; unions are blamed and discredited.

1892

Homestead Strike

Carnegie's steelworkers battle Pinkerton guards—and lose.

1894

Pullman Strike

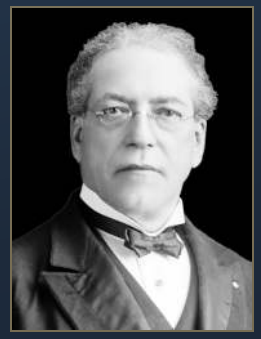
A national rail boycott is broken by federal injunction.

Two Kinds of Union

Knights of Labor

1869 · Inclusive

- Welcomed **all workers**—skilled, unskilled, women, and Black workers.
- Sought broad reforms: the 8-hour day, an end to **child labor**.
- Collapsed after being blamed for **Haymarket**.



American Federation of Labor

1886 · Skilled trades

- Organized only **skilled craft workers**.
- Led by **Samuel Gompers**—focused on 'bread-and-butter' gains.
- Used **collective bargaining** for wages and hours—and endured.

Haymarket, 1886

- A labor rally in Chicago's **Haymarket** Square turned deadly when a bomb exploded.
- The public blamed radicals and unions—especially immigrants.
- The backlash devastated the **Knights of Labor**.



Attention Workingmen!

GREAT

MASS-MEETING

TO-NIGHT, at 7.30 o'clock,

AT THE

HAYMARKET, Randolph St., Bet. Desplaines and Halsted.

Good Speakers will be present to denounce the latest atrocious act of the police, the shooting of our fellow-workmen yesterday afternoon.

Workingmen Arm Yourselves and Appear in Full Force!

THE EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE.

Achtung, Arbeiter!

Große

Massen-Versammlung

Heute Abend, ½8 Uhr, auf dem Heumarkt, Randolph-Straße, zwischen Desplaines- u. Halsted-Str.

Gute Redner werden den neuesten Schurkenstreich der Polizei, indem sie gestern Nachmittag unsere Brüder erschoß, geißeln.

Arbeiter, bewaffnet Euch und erscheint massenhaft!

Das Executiv-Comite.

SECTION

A Nation of Immigrants

The New Immigrants



- After 1880, millions of **new immigrants** arrived from Southern and Eastern Europe.
- Most passed through **Ellis Island** in New York Harbor.
- They were Catholic, Orthodox, and Jewish—fueling nativist fears.

The Growing City

- Immigrants crowded into urban **tenements**—dark, packed, and unsanitary.
- Journalist **Jacob Riis** exposed slum life in *How the Other Half Lives*.
- Rapid **urbanization** outpaced housing, sanitation, and safety.



The Great Migration

6 Million

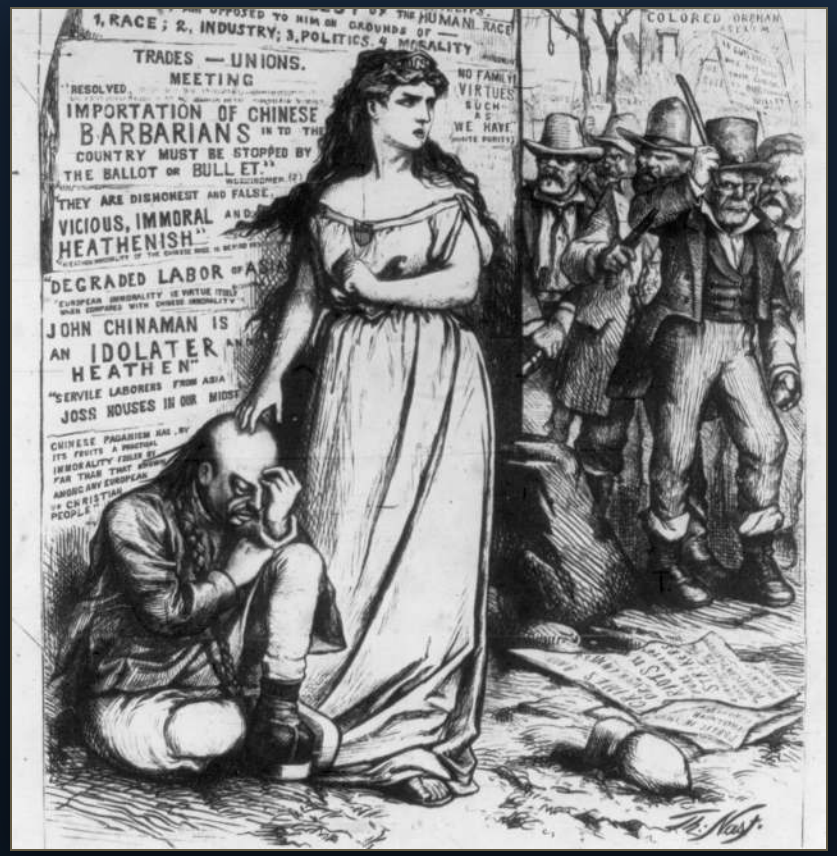
Black Southerners who left the South (1910–1970)

Escaping Jim Crow and sharecropping, African Americans moved north to industrial cities in search of jobs and freedom—reshaping American cities.

SECTION

The Backlash

Nativism & Exclusion



- **Nativism**—hostility to immigrants—surged with the new arrivals.
- The **Chinese Exclusion Act** (1882) barred Chinese laborers entirely.
- It was the first U.S. law to ban immigration by **nationality**.

Justifying Inequality

I

Social Darwinism

'Survival of the fittest' applied to society—the rich deserved their wealth.

II

The Gospel of Wealth

Carnegie argued the wealthy had a duty to give back through philanthropy.

III

Laissez-Faire

Government should not interfere with business or aid the poor.

Jane Addams & Hull House

- Reformer **Jane Addams** founded **Hull House** in Chicago in 1889.
- **Settlement houses** offered immigrants education, childcare, and job training.
- They became a launching pad for Progressive-era reform.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Labor & Immigration

1. Brutal **working conditions** and **child labor** gave rise to unions—the inclusive **Knights of Labor** and the skilled-trade **AFL** under **Samuel Gompers**.

2. A wave of **new immigrants** crowded into **Ellis Island** and urban **tenements**, fueling rapid **urbanization**.

3. A **nativist** backlash produced the **Chinese Exclusion Act**, while reformers like **Jane Addams** answered poverty with **settlement houses**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Labor & Immigration

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **industrial working conditions** gave rise to the American labor movement.

COMPARISON

Compare the **Knights of Labor** and the **AFL**. Why did the AFL prove more durable?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did **nativism** toward 'new immigrants' echo—and differ from—earlier American nativism?

Up next — **Lesson 30: The Gilded Age West & Politics** (Populism, the frontier & *Plessy*)